



ACQLERATE

MODULE 5

Capture Management & Business Development

Master the art and science of winning government contracts: from opportunity identification through proposal submission.

5 Lessons · ~96 Minutes · Lesson Book Edition

Course Lessons

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CAPTURE MANAGEMENT & BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT · LESSON 1

The BD-to-Capture Lifecycle

15 min

Understand how leading defense firms identify, qualify, and pursue government contract opportunities.

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The Capture Plan: What Every Pursuit Must Answer

- **Customer profile:** Who are the decision-makers? What do they care about most?
- **Competitive analysis:** Who will bid? What are their strengths and vulnerabilities?
- **Win themes:** 3-5 compelling reasons why your solution is the best choice for this customer
- **Discriminators:** What can your firm do that competitors cannot? (or do demonstrably better)
- **Team strategy:** Prime vs. sub; which partners add capability, contract vehicles, or customer relationships?
- **Price-to-win (PTW):** What price position will win? (Not your cost: the price that wins)
- **Risk assessment:** What could derail this capture? What's the mitigation?

Gate Review Discipline: When to Kill a Pursuit

Mid-career BD professionals understand that the hardest decision in capture management is walking away. B&P budgets are finite; every dollar spent on a low-Pwin pursuit is a dollar not spent on a winnable one. Gate reviews must be decision events: not status updates where management hears bad news and says “let's see how it goes” (three words that have quietly financed more hopeless pursuits than any competitor ever managed to). Build gate criteria that force the decision: what is the minimum Pwin below which we do not pursue? What customer access requirements must be met by Stage 2? If a \$50M opportunity has no customer access 90 days before RFP, the Pwin is probably below your threshold, and the BD team knows it. Create a gate review culture where “no pursue” decisions are celebrated as resource discipline, not treated as failures.

Pipeline Architecture: Building a Sustainable BD Engine

Senior BD executives architect the pipeline to create predictable revenue: not just chase the next opportunity. A healthy pipeline has: (1) a 3-5x coverage ratio (pipeline value 3-5x annual revenue target); (2) stage-gate distribution: 40-50% in Stage 1 (early), 30-40% in Stage 2 (capture), 20-30% in Stage 3 (proposal); (3) diversification by customer, contract type, and competitive position (not 80% incumbent). The failure mode: a

pipeline where 60% of value is in a single re-compete that has an incumbent advantage: if you lose it, revenue cratered. Architect the pipeline with a forcing function: if any single opportunity represents more than 30% of your pipeline value, you have a concentration risk that needs immediate diversification.

Managing Your Pipeline: CRM Tools for BD Teams

A spreadsheet is not a pipeline. Once you have more than 10 active opportunities, you need a Customer Relationship Management (CRM) tool to track stages, actions, and relationships. The most common in defense BD:

Salesforce (GovCon edition): The industry standard for larger contractors. Tracks opportunities from identification through award, manages contacts and account relationships, forecasts revenue, and integrates with proposal tools. Salesforce Government Cloud is FedRAMP-authorized for organizations handling sensitive data. Most large primes (Leidos, SAIC, Booz Allen) run their BD pipelines in Salesforce.

GovWin IQ + CRM integration: GovWin (by Deltek) provides market intelligence and plugs into CRM systems. Pulls opportunity data, agency budgets, and incumbent information directly into your pipeline.

Microsoft Dynamics 365: Common in mid-size contractors. Similar to Salesforce. Strong integration with Office 365 tools your capture team already uses.

Simpler options for small businesses: HubSpot (free tier), Pipedrive, or even a structured Excel/Google Sheets template are reasonable starting points before committing to enterprise CRM costs.

The discipline matters more than the tool. A well-maintained spreadsheet beats a poorly-used Salesforce instance every time, and no CRM has ever forced a BD team to actually update it before the Monday pipeline call.

What to Track in Your CRM for Every Opportunity

- Opportunity name, agency, contracting office, and NAICS code
- Estimated value and period of performance
- Anticipated RFP date and award date
- Pipeline stage: Identify → Qualify → Capture → Proposal → Award
- Pwin (Probability of Win) and last update date
- Key contacts and last engagement date
- Incumbent contractor and contract number

Key Terms

Pipeline

The portfolio of all opportunities a company is tracking at various stages of pursuit.

Pwin

Probability of Win: an estimate of the likelihood of winning a given opportunity.

B&P

Bid & Proposal: funding spent pursuing a specific opportunity (not chargeable to government contracts).

Opportunity Qualification

The process of deciding whether to invest BD resources in pursuing an opportunity (gate review).

Incumbent

The contractor currently performing work on a contract being re-competed.

Shaping

Influencing the RFP requirements, scope, and evaluation criteria before the solicitation is released.

CAPTURE MANAGEMENT & BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT · LESSON 2

Section L vs Section M: The RFP Anatomy Every Competitor Must Master

28 min

Understand the difference between Section L (instructions) and Section M (evaluation criteria), how to structure a winning proposal around Section M, and the difference between LPTA and best-value acquisitions.

Understand the difference between Section L (instructions) and Section M (evaluation criteria), how to structure a winning proposal around Section M, and the difference between LPTA and best-value acquisitions.

Why L and M Are the Two Most Important Pages in Any RFP

The Winning Proposal Process

Step 1: Read M first (identify every factor, sub-factor, and order of importance. **Step 2:** Build outline from M factors as section structure. **Step 3:** For each M sub-factor, draft 1-3 discriminating points. **Step 4:** Use L page limits to size investment) more pages to higher-weighted factors. **Step 5:** Compliance-check against L before submission.

Using Section L as a Compliance Matrix, Not Just Instructions

Mid-career proposal managers build their proposal outline directly from Section L: every instruction becomes a heading, every deliverable requirement becomes a checklist item. But the compliance matrix is the floor, not the ceiling. The government wrote Section L to describe the minimum information needed; it didn't write it to describe a winning proposal. After ensuring 100% Section L compliance, ask: what information would a SSEB evaluator want that Section L didn't require? Discriminating proposals add value beyond compliance. The most common mid-career error: a proposal that is perfectly compliant, technically correct, and about as persuasive as a tax form, saying nothing that would make an Outstanding evaluator score it above Acceptable. Compliance is table stakes; evaluation excellence is the goal.

Section M as a Negotiating Document: Shaping Evaluation Criteria Pre-RFP

Senior BD professionals know that the best time to influence Section M is before the RFP is released. Industry Days, RFIs, and pre-solicitation meetings are opportunities to educate the government program office on what evaluation criteria will produce the best outcome (and yes, everyone in the room is quietly sizing up the competition while pretending they are only there for the slides). If you have a capability that competitors lack (a

proven management approach, unique past performance, specific technical solution) you want the evaluation criteria to reward it. This is legal and expected; government contracting officers solicit industry input on acquisition strategy specifically because they lack full market knowledge. The line: you can advocate for evaluation criteria that discriminate on merit. You cannot suggest criteria designed to exclude a specific competitor by name or criteria that only your company could meet.

Key Terms

Section L

Instructions, Conditions, and Notices to Offerors: the format and packaging rules for your proposal.

Section M

Evaluation Factors for Award: the scoring rubric the government uses to evaluate proposals.

SSEB

Source Selection Evaluation Board: the government evaluators who score proposals against Section M criteria.

Strength

An aspect of a proposal that exceeds requirements and provides a documented benefit to the government.

LPTA

Lowest Price Technically Acceptable: award goes to lowest price that meets minimum technical standards.

Best Value

An acquisition approach where technical superiority can justify a higher price.

Outstanding

Highest adjectival rating: exceptional strengths, very low risk of unsuccessful performance.

Acceptable

Meets requirements but has no strengths. Often a losing rating in competitive fields.

Knowledge Check

Which section of the RFP contains the evaluation factors and their relative order of importance?

- A. Section C (Description/Specification)
- B. Section L (Instructions to Offerors)
- ✓ C. Section M (Evaluation Factors for Award)
- D. Section H (Special Contract Requirements)

WHY

Section M (Evaluation Factors for Award) is required by FAR 15.304 to disclose all evaluation factors, significant sub-factors, and their relative order of importance. This is the scoring rubric.

A proposal that violates Section L page limits can be:

- A. Penalized with a lower technical rating
- ✓ B. Rejected as non-responsive without evaluation
- C. Accepted with a CO waiver
- D. Evaluated only for the compliant portions

WHY

Administrative non-compliance with Section L typically results in rejection as non-responsive. The CO generally has no discretion to waive these requirements in a competitive source selection.

What is an “Outstanding” adjectival rating?

- A. A proposal meeting all requirements with no weaknesses
- ✓ B. A proposal with exceptional strengths significantly benefiting the government and very low risk
- C. A proposal with one strength and no weaknesses
- D. The highest price-to-performance proposal

WHY

Outstanding requires exceptional strengths (plural) that significantly benefit the government, very low risk of unsuccessful performance. It requires benefits well above threshold requirements.

Under LPTA, which proposal wins?

- A. The technically superior proposal
- B. The best value tradeoff between technical and price
- ✓ C. The lowest-priced proposal that meets minimum technical requirements
- D. The proposal with the highest past performance rating

WHY

LPTA awards to the lowest-priced technically acceptable proposal. Once technical acceptability is established, only price matters: fundamentally different from best-value tradeoff.

The best practice for structuring a proposal in best-value source selection is to:

- A. Follow the SOW section by section
- B. Mirror Section L volume structure only
- ✓ C. Mirror Section M factor/sub-factor structure as the proposal outline
- D. Use the company standard proposal template

WHY

Winning proposals mirror Section M factor and sub-factor structure in section headers. This makes it easy for evaluators to find and credit strengths. Section L defines the container; Section M defines the content architecture.

CAPTURE MANAGEMENT & BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT · LESSON 3

Proposal Development & Win Strategy

14 min

Write and review proposals that win: from compliance matrices to compelling executive summaries.

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The Six Core Proposal Volumes

- **Executive Summary:** State your win themes and discriminators upfront: 2 pages maximum
- **Technical Approach:** Describe HOW you will solve the problem: specific, not generic
- **Management Approach:** How will you staff, manage, and deliver? Show your program management process
- **Past Performance:** Analogous contracts with measurable results: quality over quantity
- **Price/Cost Volume:** Realistic, well-supported pricing with clear assumptions
- **Compliance Matrix:** Every Section L requirement mapped to your proposal response

Running an Effective Color Review

Mid-career capture managers know that the value of a color review is entirely dependent on the quality of the reviewers and the specificity of the feedback. Pink Team: bring in functional experts (finance, technical, past performance) who are not on the proposal team: they catch assumptions the team has normalized. Red Team: requires evaluators who can simulate the government SSEB: ideally former contracting officers or program managers who have run source selections. The most common failure mode: Red Teams staffed with company employees who are reluctant to give negative feedback, because nobody wants to be the reason a colleague spends the weekend rewriting Volume 1. Fix this by bringing in external Red Team members, pre-briefing reviewers on the evaluation criteria, and requiring scores on each factor using the adjectival rating scale the government will use.

Win Strategy Architecture: From Theme to Section M Score

Senior capture professionals build win strategies backwards from Section M. For each evaluation factor, ask: what would an Outstanding/Blue rating require? Then work backwards to the proposal section: what text, graphics, and proof points substantiate that claim? Then work backwards to the solution: does our technical approach actually deliver what an Outstanding rating requires? If the answer is no, the problem is the solution: not the proposal. This “Section M backwards” discipline exposes the gap between what the proposal team wants

to claim and what the technical team can actually deliver. Close that gap before the proposal starts, not during the Red Team. The most elegant proposal for a mediocre solution still loses, no matter how many gradients and arrows the graphics team adds to the cover page.

Key Terms

Compliance Matrix

A document cross-referencing every Section L requirement against the proposal section that addresses it.

Discriminator

A specific, provable capability or attribute that differentiates your proposal from competitors' proposals.

Ghosting

Subtly highlighting a competitor's weakness in your proposal without naming them directly.

Win Theme

A compelling, customer-specific message that explains why your solution best meets the customer's need.

APMP

Association of Proposal Management Professionals: the industry organization for proposal professionals.

Executive Summary

The first and most read section of a proposal: must convey all win themes and discriminators concisely.

CAPTURE MANAGEMENT & BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT · LESSON 4

Source Selection: From Solicitation to Award Decision

25 min

Understand the government source selection process from the inside: roles, evaluation phases, discussions, and the award decision.

Understand the government source selection process from the inside (roles, evaluation phases, discussions, and the award decision) essential knowledge for both government PMs and industry capture teams.

How the Government Picks a Winner: The Source Selection Process

Source selection is the formal government process for evaluating competitive proposals and making a contract award decision. It is governed by FAR Part 15 and, for DoD, supplemented by the DoD Source Selection Procedures (2016). Understanding this process from the GOVERNMENT side is essential for both government PMs (who participate in it) and industry professionals (who must build proposals that work within it, usually while explaining to an executive that no, there is not a faster way).

Debriefs as Competitive Intelligence: Maximizing the Post-Award Debrief

Mid-career capture professionals treat every debrief (win or lose) as the most valuable data point in their next proposal, and about the closest thing capture management has to a group therapy session. In a post-award debrief, the government must reveal: your adjectival ratings by factor, the awardee's ratings by factor (not their scores), significant strengths and weaknesses identified in your proposal, and the overall rationale for the best-value determination. From this data, you can reconstruct: what exactly did you score as a weakness that you thought was a strength? Where did the awardee outperform you? Was it price, technical, or past performance? Build a debrief data log: track every weakness across all debriefs. If you see the same weakness cited on three consecutive proposals, you have a systemic capability gap, not a proposal writing problem.

GAO Protest Strategy: When to Protest and When Not To

Senior BD executives make protest decisions based on a structured analysis, not emotional reaction to a loss, however satisfying that 2 a.m. email to the contracting officer would feel to draft. Protest when: (1) the government made a clear evaluation error that is documented in the debrief (wrong ratings, failure to apply stated criteria, unequal treatment); (2) the protest has a reasonable probability of sustaining (GAO sustains ~15-20%); (3) the contract value justifies the cost and disruption of a protest (typically \$20M+); (4) a corrective action by the government (re-evaluation or re-solicitation) would change the outcome. Don't protest when: the

government made the right decision and your proposal genuinely lost on the merits; the protest is designed to delay performance rather than win the contract. GAO protests are public record: a pattern of losing protests without sustaining damages your reputation with government customers.

Key Terms

SSA

Source Selection Authority: the official who makes the final award decision and signs the Source Selection Decision Document.

SSEB

Source Selection Evaluation Board: the team of technical and management SMEs who evaluate proposals and assign adjectival ratings.

SSAC

Source Selection Advisory Council: the senior body that reviews SSEB findings, conducts tradeoff analysis, and recommends an award to the SSA.

SSDD

Source Selection Decision Document: the signed document where the SSA documents the best-value rationale for the award decision.

EN

Evaluation Notice: a written question from the SSEB to an offeror during discussions, required to address all Deficiencies and Significant Weaknesses.

FPR

Final Proposal Revision: the revised proposal submitted by offerors after discussions are closed, which is the basis for final evaluation.

Competitive Range

The set of proposals with a realistic chance of award. The CO may exclude proposals outside the competitive range before discussions.

SSP

Source Selection Plan: the document approved by the SSA before solicitation release that defines evaluation factors, weights, rating scales, and the evaluation process.

Knowledge Check

Who makes the final award decision in a source selection?

- A. The SSEB Chair
- B. The Contracting Officer (CO)
- ✓ C. The Source Selection Authority (SSA)
- D. The SSAC Chair

WHY

The SSA makes the final award decision and signs the SSDD. The SSAC provides a recommendation, but the SSA makes an independent judgment. The CO executes the contract but does not make the selection decision.

If the government holds discussions with one offeror in the competitive range, they must:

- ✓ A. Hold discussions with all offerors in the competitive range
- B. Notify only the offeror with the lowest price
- C. Issue a sole source amendment
- D. Close the solicitation and restart

WHY

FAR 15.306 requires that if discussions are held with any offeror in the competitive range, the government must hold discussions with ALL offerors in the competitive range. Selective discussions would provide an unfair advantage.

An Evaluation Notice (EN) issued during discussions must address:

- A. Only price issues
- B. Only strengths
- ✓ C. All deficiencies and significant weaknesses identified by the SSEB
- D. Administrative corrections only

WHY

FAR 15.306(d) requires the CO to inform each offeror of all Deficiencies, Significant Weaknesses, and adverse past performance information. ENs are the mechanism for this.

How many days after award notification does an offeror have to request a post-award debrief?

✓ **A. 3 calendar days**

B. 10 calendar days

C. 30 calendar days

D. 60 calendar days

WHY

Under FAR 15.506, an unsuccessful offeror must request a debrief within 3 days of receiving the award notification. Missing this deadline waives the right to a mandatory debrief.

A “competitive range determination” is used to:

A. Set the price range for negotiations

✓ **B. Exclude proposals with no realistic chance of award before discussions**

C. Rank proposals by price

D. Determine which evaluation factors are most important

WHY

A competitive range determination (FAR 15.306(c)) allows the CO to exclude proposals with no reasonable chance of selection, streamlining the evaluation process. Excluded offerors receive notification and the right to request a pre-award debrief.

CAPTURE MANAGEMENT & BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT · LESSON 5

5 Most Common Mistakes Contractors Make (And How to Avoid Them)

14 min

The five systematic errors that cost defense contractors contracts, relationships, and revenue: drawn from real patterns across BD, capture, proposal, and performance operations.

The five systematic errors that cost defense contractors contracts, relationships, and revenue: drawn from real patterns across BD, capture, proposal, and performance operations.

Why Experienced Contractors Keep Making These Mistakes

The five mistakes in this lesson are not beginner errors: they are systematic gaps in pipeline strategy, relationship management, and compliance posture that show up across defense contractors of all sizes, from small businesses to large primes. They persist because they are organizational failures, not individual ones. Fixing them requires process changes, not just awareness.

Mistake #1: No Pipeline Strategy: Chasing vs. Planning

The most common and costly mistake: treating BD as reactive rather than strategic. Contractors who chase every opportunity on SAM.gov without a disciplined pipeline framework waste proposal resources, burn out their teams, and win at low rates. A mature pipeline strategy identifies target customers 12–18 months before RFP release, maps vehicle opportunities aligned to your NAICS codes and capabilities, and scores every opportunity by pWin before committing proposal resources. Without this, you are funding your competitor's market research, because every proposal you submit at low pWin consumes resources that could have been focused on winnable work.

Pipeline Discipline: What a Mature System Looks Like

- **Minimum 18-month horizon:** opportunities should enter your pipeline at least 18 months before RFP, giving you time to shape requirements, build relationships, and position your solution.
- **pWin gate:** no opportunity proceeds to active capture without a documented pWin assessment. Typical thresholds: below 25% = watch only; 25–50% = selective investment; above 50% = full capture investment. (And if every opportunity on your pipeline somehow scores 70% or higher, the pWin gate is broken, not your BD team.)
- **Vehicle alignment:** every opportunity in the pipeline must map to a vehicle you hold or are pursuing. If you don't have the vehicle, pursuing the opportunity is premature.

- **Qualification criteria:** define your “no bid” criteria before you see opportunities. Common no-bid signals include incumbent with strong CPARS, requirement written around competitor capabilities, and budget not yet appropriated.

Mistake #2: Ignoring the COR: Focusing Only on the CO

The Contracting Officer's Representative is the government's day-to-day technical interface during contract performance, and one of the most influential voices in CPARS ratings and recompetes positioning. Contractors who treat the COR as an administrative checkpoint rather than a strategic relationship miss the single best source of performance feedback, requirement shaping intelligence, and past performance narrative. (A warm relationship with the customer and an actual signed contract are not the same thing, however easy the two are to confuse.) Build a structured engagement plan with the COR from contract kickoff. Deliver proactive status updates, document issues in writing, and ensure your PM treats every COR interaction as a performance evaluation in progress.

Mistake #3: Confusing PWS and SOW: Proposing the Wrong Way

A Statement of Work tells you what to do in prescriptive, task-level detail. A Performance Work Statement tells you what outcome to achieve, leaving the method to the contractor. These are not interchangeable, and responding to a PWS with a SOW-style proposal (listing activities instead of outcomes) is a red flag to evaluators. It signals your team doesn't understand performance-based contracting, which is the dominant acquisition model in services. PWS-based proposals should describe your management framework, quality metrics, and how you measure and demonstrate outcomes: not a labor hour breakdown by task.

SOW vs. PWS: How Your Proposal Should Respond

ELEMENT	SOW-BASED CONTRACT	PWS-BASED CONTRACT
Government specifies	Specific tasks to be performed	Performance outcomes and standards
Contractor proposes	How it will execute each task	Management approach + how it will measure/achieve outcomes
Evaluation focus	Technical approach to tasks	Quality management, metrics, and performance framework
Pricing approach	Labor category + hours by task	Outcome-based; contractor owns the “how”
Risk allocation	Government bears method risk	Contractor bears method risk; government bears requirements risk
Common mistake	N/A	Responding like an SOW: listing tasks instead of outcomes and metrics

Mistake #4: DCAA Compliance Gaps Discovered at the Worst Time

The Defense Contract Audit Agency (yes, another “Defense” in the name; the rebrand paperwork has not caught up to the audit staff yet) conducts pre-award surveys, incurred cost audits, and forward pricing reviews that can kill a contract award or trigger costly remediation during performance. Contractors (especially those transitioning from commercial work to cost-reimbursable contracts) frequently discover DCAA compliance gaps only after award, when the pressure is highest. Common gaps include inadequate timekeeping systems, unallowable cost pooling, missing written policies for compensation and travel, and indirect rate structures that don't align to contract requirements. Establish a compliant accounting system before pursuing cost-type work. Engage a DCAA-savvy CPA or contracts attorney before your first cost-reimbursable award: not after.

Most Common DCAA Compliance Gaps: Fix Before Award

- **Timekeeping system:** must capture time by contract/project daily, not estimated retroactively. DCAA requires contemporaneous timekeeping; this is non-negotiable.
- **Unallowable cost segregation:** FAR 31.205 identifies numerous unallowable cost categories (entertainment, alcohol, certain lobbying). These must be segregated in your accounting system before incurred cost submissions.
- **Written policies:** compensation, travel, and overtime policies must be in writing and consistently applied. Verbal policies are invisible to auditors and unenforceable.
- **Indirect rate structure:** your labor categories, overhead pools, and G&A base must align to how work is actually organized and priced. Misalignment creates audit findings that require costly restructuring mid-contract.

Mistake #5: No Recompete Plan: Losing What You Already Won

Contractors routinely focus 90% of their capture energy on new business while neglecting the most winnable opportunity in their portfolio: the contract they already hold. The incumbent win rate on federal contracts is not as high as most contractors assume, and a poorly executed recompetete can erase years of revenue in a single award decision. Recompetete planning should begin at contract award: not 12 months before expiration. A recompetete plan documents performance wins, maintains CPARS narrative alignment, tracks staffing continuity risks, monitors competitive intelligence on challenger firms, and coordinates capture strategy with delivery teams in real time.

Recompete Planning Timeline: Start at Award

PHASE	TIMING	KEY ACTIONS
Foundation	Award → Month 6	Document transition execution, establish COR relationship, baseline performance metrics, start CPARS narrative file
Performance Building	Month 6 → 36	Deliver above expectations, proactively document wins, engage COR monthly, identify staffing risks, monitor competitor positioning
Pre-Recompete	24 months before expiration	Formal recompete plan activation, competitive intelligence refresh, pricing strategy development, key personnel retention plan
Active Capture	12 months before RFP	Requirement shaping, customer validation, Black Hat assessment, proposal team assembly, price-to-win analysis
Proposal	RFP release	Full proposal execution with incumbent advantage messaging, past performance narrative, continuous improvement story

Key Terms

pWin

Probability of Win: an assessment of the likelihood of winning a specific opportunity, typically expressed as a percentage. Used in gate reviews to determine whether to invest proposal resources.

Pipeline Strategy

A disciplined approach to identifying, qualifying, and sequencing pursuit opportunities 12–18 months before RFP release, aligned to NAICS codes, vehicle positions, and win probability thresholds.

CPARS

Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System: the government's official record of contractor performance. High CPARS ratings are essential past performance evidence for future proposals.

COR

Contracting Officer's Representative: the government's day-to-day technical interface during contract performance. One of the most influential voices in CPARS ratings and recompile positioning.

SOW

Statement of Work: prescriptive task-level description of work. Tells the contractor exactly what to do.

PWS

Performance Work Statement: outcome-based description of required performance. Tells the contractor what result to achieve, leaving the method to the contractor.

DCAA

Defense Contract Audit Agency: conducts pre-award surveys, incurred cost audits, and forward pricing reviews. DCAA compliance gaps can kill contract awards or trigger costly remediation.

Recompile

The process of re-competing an existing contract at expiration. Incumbents have advantages, but lose at higher rates than most contractors assume if they don't actively manage recompile risk.

Incurred Cost Audit

DCAA audit of a contractor's actual costs incurred on cost-reimbursable contracts. Filed annually via the Incurred Cost Submission (ICS).

Knowledge Check

A contractor's pipeline shows 40 active opportunities, only 3 of which have pWin assessments above 40%. What does this indicate?

- A. Strong BD performance (a large pipeline maximizes win probability)
- ✓ **B. An undisciplined pipeline strategy that is likely wasting proposal resources on low-probability pursuits**
- C. The contractor should increase proposal volume to improve win totals
- D. Normal BD operations) most opportunities in any pipeline have low pWin

WHY

A pipeline dominated by low-pWin opportunities signals reactive, undisciplined BD. Proposal resources are finite: investing them in low-probability pursuits reduces the quality of proposals on winnable work. A mature pipeline prioritizes opportunities where the contractor has competitive advantages and validated customer relationships.

Why is the COR more strategically important than most contractors realize?

- A. The COR has authority to award contract modifications over \$150,000
- ✓ **B. The COR is the primary author of CPARS ratings and the most influential voice in recompute positioning**
- C. The COR controls the government's budget allocation for the contract
- D. The COR approves all invoices before the CO processes payment

WHY

The COR is the government's day-to-day technical interface and one of the most influential voices in CPARS ratings. A strong COR relationship directly impacts past performance ratings, recompute intelligence, and requirement shaping. Contractors who treat CORs as administrative checkpoints consistently underperform on recomputes.

A solicitation uses a Performance Work Statement. How should a contractor's technical proposal respond?

- A. Provide a detailed task-by-task breakdown with labor hours per activity
- ✓ **B. Describe the management framework, quality metrics, and how outcomes will be measured and achieved**
- C. Mirror the PWS structure with a direct response to each performance standard
- D. Propose a fixed schedule of deliverables aligned to the government's task list

WHY

PWS-based proposals should focus on management approach, quality management framework, and how the contractor will measure and demonstrate achievement of outcomes. Responding with a task-by-task activity list (SOW-style) signals a fundamental misunderstanding of performance-based contracting and is a red flag to evaluators.

Which DCAA compliance requirement is described as “non-negotiable” for contractors on cost-reimbursable work?

A. Monthly financial reporting to the contracting officer

✓ B. Contemporaneous timekeeping: capturing time by contract daily, not retroactively

C. Written compensation policies approved by the CO before award

D. Independent audit of indirect rates by a certified public accountant

WHY

Contemporaneous timekeeping (capturing employee time by contract or project daily) is DCAA's most fundamental requirement and is non-negotiable. Retroactive time estimates or after-the-fact adjustments are a primary finding in DCAA audits and can result in cost disallowances, system rejection, and contract termination.

When should a contractor formally activate its recompile plan?

A. 12 months before contract expiration, when the RFP timeline becomes clear

B. 6 months before expiration, when the government issues a pre-solicitation notice

✓ C. At contract award: the moment the current period of performance begins

D. 30 days before proposal submission deadline

WHY

Recompile planning should begin at contract award: not 12 months before expiration. The entire period of performance is recompile positioning time. CPARS narratives, performance documentation, competitive intelligence, and staffing continuity plans all need to be built over the life of the contract, not assembled in a last-minute rush before the RFP.